

Rick Steves and the Making of the Middle-Class Tourist: How Rick Steves Redefined Travel as a Middle-Class Identity and the Structural Barriers That Persist

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I declare that this thesis is my independent work. All sources and literature are cited and included.

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Abstract

This thesis analyzes how Rick Steves reshaped American Travel to Europe by presenting it as ethical, educational, and accessible to the middle class. Through his television programs, guidebooks, and political travel writing, Steves teaches his audiences more than where to travel, but how to travel “correctly.” His work focuses on a model of the good traveler as curious, respectful, historically aware, budget conscious, and open to cultural differences. Using theories such as the tourist gaze, cultural capital, staged authenticity, and tourism inequality, this thesis argues that Steves does not just remove class from travel, but rather translates older forms of travel privilege into a middle class language of learning, humility, and being culturally aware. His work broadens cultural access by making Europe feel more understandable and approachable for an American audience. However this does not remove the structural barriers which continue to shape who can travel in the first place, such as money, time, passport privilege, legal means, and freedom from everyday responsibilities. Ultimately, this thesis argues that Rick Steves democratizes travel while also simultaneously reproducing inequality. He makes travel feel more open and meaningful, but inside a system where international mobility stays unequally distributed.

Keywords

Rick Steves; tourism; middle class identity; cultural capital; tourist gaze; staged authenticity; structural inequality; American tourism

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Introduction

International travel, particularly Americans traveling abroad to Europe, has long been tied to class, power, and access. Who gets to travel, where they go, and how they are expected to behave abroad has never been neutral. For much of modern history, international travel (especially to Europe) functioned as a marker of elite status, cultural refinement, and economic privilege. Over time, mass tourism expanded in participation, but it did not remove the underlying inequalities that continue to shape who is able to travel internationally. Instead, travel increasingly became a way of expressing class distinction through taste, behavior, and cultural knowledge rather than an overt display of wealth.

It is within this longer history of classed travel that Rick Steves has become one of the most influential figures shaping how Americans imagine and experience Europe. Through television programs, guidebooks, and digital platforms, Steves presents travel as humble, ethical, curious and achievable. Rather than framing European travel as an exclusive activity for the wealthy, he presents it as an accessible “classroom” where ordinary Americans can learn how to engage with history, culture, and everyday life abroad. His message consistently emphasizes respect, simplicity and more budget-friendly choices, painting travel as a moral and educational practice rather than luxury.

This thesis draws on Pierre Bourdieu’s concept of cultural capital and competence, which refers to the knowledge, skills, and cultural competencies that demonstrate social distinction rather than wealth alone. In the context of travel, this includes the ability to understand cultural sites, navigate unfamiliar environments, and demonstrate appropriate behavior abroad. Importantly, this knowledge is not limited

to the travel experience but is carried back home and used to signal taste, legitimacy, and distinction in everyday life.

This thesis argues that Rick Steves did not remove class from travel but rather translated it. His media trains a specific middle-class tourist identity by teaching his viewers how to evaluate “authenticity,” how to navigate European cities, how to interact with locals, and how to distinguish meaningful travel from superficial tourism. While Steves expands cultural access by making Europe feel approachable and legible, he does not meaningfully challenge the structural barriers that are still in place which determine who can travel in the first place. His version of “travel for everyone” is cultural rather than structural, working inside the existing inequalities around income, passports, visas, language and free time.

This distinction between cultural access and structural access is at the core of my argument. Cultural access refers to making travel feel understandable, readable, and emotionally possible for a wider audience. Structural access refers to the actual material ability to travel, which depends on money, free time, legal mobility, and geopolitical privilege. He teaches viewers how to interpret Europe, how to move through it, and how to feel that they actually belong there. However, this does not actually change the second layer of access, which still remains unequally distributed. This gap is why Steves appears democratic while still speaking to people who already have the means to go.

This thesis therefore does not argue that Rick Steves is simply repeating old elite travel models, nor does it argue that he fully democratizes travel. Instead, it argues that he transforms the meaning of travel within an already unequal system. He takes something that used to be tied to elite cultivation and reframes it in a middle-class language—self-improvement, humility, knowledge, and ethical travel. That shift makes

travel feel much less exclusive but doesn't actually make it structurally equal. That is where Steves' significance comes from.

In this thesis, tourism refers to voluntary travel outside of one's home environment for leisure, done in contrast to everyday responsibilities, such as work and home life. This idea comes from Dennison Nash, who defines tourism as a form of leisure travel, which is built around a temporary break from those everyday obligations (Nash, 1981, p. 462). Looking at tourism in this type of way confirms that travel is more than movement across space, but a social relationship shaped by unequal access to mobility.

By examining Rick Steves' work through theories of the tourist gaze, cultural capital, staged authenticity, and travel capitalism, this project explores how media shapes not only destinations, but the travelers themselves. At its core, it asks whether Rick Steves democratizes travel or rearticulates the existing privilege in a more ethical and approachable form. Rather than treating these as opposing outcomes, this thesis argues that both of these processes happen simultaneously. Steves expands cultural access to travel while also constructing a distinctly middle-class framework that shapes how travel should be experienced, interpreted, and valued. In doing so, travel becomes more than just an activity. It shapes identity. As people gain cultural capital abroad, they use it at home to express taste and legitimacy. However, as more people gain this knowledge, its value as a marker of distinction fades, which pushes elites to find new ways to stand out.

This thesis analyzes episodes of the PBS television program *Rick Steves' Europe*, selections from his guidebooks including *Europe through the Back Door*, and his political travel writing such as *Travel as a Political Act*. Through close textual and visual analysis, the project looks at narration, framing, editing choices, and repeated

thematic patterns. These materials are interpreted through the theoretical frameworks of John Urry's concept of the tourist gaze, Pierre Bourdieu's theory of cultural capital and distinction, Dean MacCannell's idea of staged authenticity, and scholarship on tourism and global inequality. Together, these frameworks allow a deeper understanding not only of destinations, but of how the media shapes the identity of a traveler.

Chapter 1 - The Problem: Travel, Class, and Access

Before looking at Rick Steves, it is important to understand the structure he is working inside. While travel broadly refers to the movement between places, tourism is a more specific, organized form of travel shaped by leisure, consumption, and social expectations. Tourism did not emerge as something democratic. From its earliest forms, it functioned as a social practice shaped by hierarchy and access.

To understand how these dynamics continue, it is important to define tourism more clearly. Dennison Nash defines tourism as leisure travel outside one's usual environment, undertaken "free of primary obligations" and leaving home temporarily with the expectation of return (Nash, 1981, p. 462). This definition shows that tourism depends on having time, money, and security to travel (which are conditions not equally available to everyone).

Tourism is also shaped by broader economic inequalities. As Jared Diamond argues, tourism's economic benefits are often overstated because money doesn't just stay local, a significant portion of revenue leaks out through imports, infrastructure costs, and other structural constraints, limiting how much local communities actually benefit (Diamond, 1977, pp. 552-553). In this way, tourism can reinforce existing global inequalities rather than reducing them.

At the same time, tourism is not only structured economically, but also culturally. John Urry's concept of the "tourist gaze" explains how tourists see places through expectations shaped by media and prior knowledge (Urry, 2002, pp. 1-3). What counts as authentic or meaningful is therefore not natural but socially constructed.

Historically, international travel was used as a marker of elite identity. From the seventeenth through the nineteenth centuries, the Grand Tour served as a

passage for wealthy young European men, particularly from Britain, who would travel across France, Italy, and other cultural centers to complete their education. The journey was not taken for leisure in the modern sense but as a form of cultural training. Exposure to classical art, architecture, and political institutions was meant to cultivate refinement, taste, and social legitimacy (Urry, 2002, pp. 4-5).

Travel in this period functioned as an extension of elite education rather than recreation (Urry, 2002, pp. 4-5). Moving from place to place was only one part of it; the real focus was on learning how to recognize cultural values and develop social distinction. In Bourdieu's terms, this reflects the building of cultural capital, where knowledge of art, history, and culture becomes a resource that signals legitimacy (Bourdieu, 1984, pp. 2-3).

The older model is significant to understand Rick Steves because his work keeps part of that same logic, just in a different form. It is no longer about elite refinement, personal instruction or elite authority. Instead, the focus shifts to ethical awareness, historical understanding, traveling on a budget, and being culturally aware. But the core idea is still there: travel matters not just because you go somewhere, but because you come back changed in a way that actually means something socially. The traveler returns home with not just memories, but with a kind of cultivated identity.

As transportation expanded through industrialization, tourism became more accessible to middle-class populations. Railways and steamships made international travel more logistically possible, while the growth of organized tours and travel services helped to expand access even further. Although participation increased, structural inequality did not disappear. While affordability remained central, distinction increasingly operated through style, taste, and cultural knowledge. In the

late nineteenth and twentieth centuries, improvements in communication and transportation made travel less difficult, dangerous, and time-consuming, while the rise of a salaried middle-class made leisure travel more possible for larger numbers of people (Cohen, 1972, p. 166). By the nineteenth century, tourism was no longer confined to aristocratic elites but had become an increasingly normalized feature of modern life. It is at this historical moment that John Urry's concept of the "tourist gaze" becomes especially useful for understanding how travel operates socially.

John Urry argues that tourism is not a minor social activity, it is a defining feature of modern life (Urry, 2002, pp. 1-2). Modern societies structure clear separation between everyday routine and extraordinary experience. Travel becomes meaningful because it interrupts normal life (Urry, 2002, pp. 1-2). It is not random; it is shaped around the idea of escaping from everyday routines and responsibilities. What makes tourism distinct is this contrast between ordinary and extraordinary. Tourists look for experiences that feel different from their daily environments, whether it is through new terrain, cultures or activities. However, these experiences are not completely spontaneous. They are shaped by expectations about what counts as "worth seeing", which is influenced by media and cultural narratives.

Anthropologist Dennison Nash argues that tourism should be understood as a structured type of cultural contact rather than leisure consumption. He describes tourism as arising from "the intersection of the histories of two or more cultures or subcultures", highlighting the importance of cross-cultural interaction in shaping the tourist experience (Nash, 1981, p. 463). That is significant because that kind of freedom is not universal. Being "free of primary obligations" assumes one has the money, legal stability, and enough control over your time to step away. Tourism might look like freedom, but it actually rests on privilege. The people most able to travel are

the ones whose jobs, passports, and economic situations allow them to leave without risk.

This is a useful point of transition because it demonstrates tourism always operates on two levels at once. On one level, it is framed as a choice, pleasure, curiosity, and personal freedom. On the other level, it depends on unequal access to money, time, security, and mobility. These two sides do not cancel each other out; they work together. The more tourism is presented as open and freeing, the easier it is to overlook what actually makes that freedom possible in the first place. That tension is especially clear with Rick Steves, whose work expands the feeling of openness but leaves the material limited, mostly untouched.

A country might earn foreign exchange and create jobs, but that does not mean the benefits are actually evenly distributed. Resorts, cruise ports, and packaged tourist zones can separate visitors from everyday local life. So even if an individual tourist tries to be respectful or “authentic”, the system underneath them can still be unequal.

This is a structural side of my argument, travel can feel ethical at an individual level but still moves through the economic systems that shape inequality. It is inside this system that Rick Steves builds his version of ethical, middle-class travel.

Chapter 2 - Rick Steves and the Training of the Tourist Gaze

To answer whether Rick Steves democratizes travel or instead reframes existing privilege, it is important to be clear about what he actually achieves. Steves provides more than a guide or a travel host in recommending hotels or restaurants. Through his books, television episodes, lectures and social media, Steves consistently educates Americans on how to travel to Europe. He trains his audience in what counts as meaningful, respectful and “good” travel.

This is where Urry's idea of the tourist gaze comes in again. If tourism is a socially organized way of seeing (Urry, 2002, p. 1), then media influencers like Steves help shape how people visualize a place before they even travel there. His programs function more like lessons. Steves explains a site's history, demonstrates how to engage with locals, and suggests what “real” or “authentic” travel looks like. He presents Europe while teaching his audience how to understand and absorb it.

In *Europe Through the Back Door*, Steves emphasizes the importance of avoiding what he calls “tourist traps” and instead becoming a “temporary local.” That phrase alone reveals the deeper argument. The goal is not simply to see famous sites, but to perform a kind of cultural awareness. The good traveler, in Steves' eyes, is curious, modest, and willing to step outside their comfort zone, but in controlled and manageable ways. This modesty can also be understood in relation to American global power at the time Steves is developing his brand. As the United States holds a dominant position, American travelers carry that privilege with them abroad. Rather than expressing that openly, Steves reframes it through humility, encouraging travelers to appear respectful and self-aware. This modesty does not remove power; it just reshapes how it appears.

In this sense, Steves acts less like a traditional traveler and more like a cultural teacher. In addition to providing information about specific destinations, Steves also teaches a set of travel ethics. His narration often carries an implied lesson about what kind of response a place deserves, encouraging viewers to “travel like a temporary local”. A cathedral is not just the subject matter of a photo. It is a cultural landmark to be respected. A local tradition is not just something to witness. It is a custom to appreciate and understand. A market is not just a surface level attraction. It is a part of daily life, reflecting how locals shop, socialize, and sustain their communities. This kind of instructional tone is one of the main ways Rick Steves shapes the tourist gaze. He is not just telling viewers where to look— he is teaching them how to look in the right way.

That is part of why Rick Steves resonates so strongly with middle-class audiences. The kind of travel he promotes feels manageable rather than overwhelming. It pushes viewers a bit outside of their comfort zone, but only in ways that are structured and predictable. His itineraries, narration, and advice reduce uncertainty, turning unfamiliar places into something that feels understandable and safe. He encourages openness, but not total surrender, independence, but not full uncertainty. You are meant to feel adventurous but still guided. That balance matters because it lowers the anxiety that can come with international travel. Europe ends up feeling foreign enough to be meaningful, but still clear enough to handle. This balance reflects a specific middle-class position: travel is both an investment and a learning experience, so risk has to be managed. The goal is to travel the “right” way rather than just going somewhere new.

This connects closely to Cohen’s idea of the “environmental bubble”. Tourists often experience foreign places through familiar structures, what Erik Cohen

describes as an "environmental bubble", allowing them to encounter differences without completely leaving the comfort of their own cultural norms (Cohen, 1972, pp. 166-168). Although Steves critiques superficial tourism and encourages deeper engagement, his approach still gives a carefully curated experience. His guidebooks map out routes, recommend specific places, and even suggest how to interact with locals. For example, he often advises travelers to "skip the line" at major tourist attractions by arriving early or using specific entrances, and he highlights small, family run restaurants over heavy tourist spots. He also gives behavioral advice, such as learning a few local phrases. Even moments of "authentic" interaction (like visiting a market or taking public transportation) are chosen and explained in advance. This creates the feeling of independent discovery, but within a structured and guided framework.

In this way, Steves does not remove the protective "bubble" of tourism but rather reorganizes it. What feels like independent and genuine exploration is still guided and organized in a way that makes it feel comfortable and approachable for his audience. Being guided is part of what makes the experience meaningful. It signals that one is travelling thoughtfully and "correctly", rather than blindly following mass tourism. In this sense, guidance itself becomes a mark of distinction.

That does not mean his work is meaningless or insincere. In many ways, Steves genuinely pushes against luxury tourism and encourages Americans to face their cultural assumptions. In *Travel as a Political Act*, he explicitly explains travel as something more than leisure, arguing that "travel is a political act". He reinforces this idea by suggesting that travel can reshape how Americans understand the world, claiming that if people traveled, "the political landscape of the USA would be vastly different". Similarly, he argues that "fear is for people who don't get out much",

indicating travel can be a method to replace fear with understanding. Together, these statements represent travel as a form of personal and political growth. Europe becomes less of a place of consumption and more of a space for learning. However, this ideology is not neutral. It defines the “good traveler” as open minded and globally aware, turning perspective and understanding into markers of distinction.

That shift in itself is significant. In this shift, travel becomes a way of signaling how one should engage with the world. The traveler is not just someone who can afford a plane ticket. The traveler becomes someone who travels the “right” way. Budget conscious, historically aware, politically informed, and respectful toward local culture. This creates a specific middle-class attraction. Luxury tourists are criticized for excess, and package tourists are condemned for superficiality. The ideal traveler is informed, thoughtful, and culturally literate. Importantly, this model is revealed in a particular historical moment. With the first edition of *Europe Through the Back Door* published in 1980, Steves’ approach launches at the same time mass tourism is growing, and more middle-class Americans are travelling abroad. In that context, the focus on “doing travel right” shows a bigger shift toward ethical consumption.

This lines up with scholarship on the American middle-class that emphasizes knowledge and cultural awareness as markers of status rather than wealth alone. In the United States, researchers have shown a shift away from the traditional idea of an exclusive cultural elite towards what Richard Peterson calls the “omnivore”, someone who gains status by showing familiarity with a wide range of cultural forms (Peterson, 1992, p. 252). In this sense, distinction is not about luxury or elite experiences anymore, it is about demonstrating that you're aware, adaptable, and culturally informed. Steves fits into this change by showing travel as something where curiosity, cultural engagement, and openness matter more than wealth.

What once felt overwhelming becomes clear and structured. For many American middle-class travelers (particularly those without prior international experience) Europe can feel unfamiliar and difficult to navigate. Language differences, transportation systems, and cultural norms can create uncertainty. Travel requires confidence to move through unfamiliar places.

Steves addresses this by breaking down transportation systems step by step, explaining the tipping practices, and providing historical and cultural context for smaller towns. From doing this, he reduces the uncertainty that can make international travel feel inaccessible or uncomfortable. Europe then turns from something of an elite playground into something that can be learned and understood.

This connects to middle-class values of preparation, self-improvement, and cultural competence. Bourdieu argues that cultural competence is learned through institutions like family and school, which teach people what counts as valuable cultural behavior and what does not (Bourdieu, 1984, p. 85). Because the tourist gaze is socially structured, Steves' guidance also teaches travelers how to interpret unfamiliar places in ways that feel natural and legitimate (Urry, 2002, pp. 1-3). What matters is that the ability to navigate the "right" way becomes a marker of distinction in itself.

At the same time, this expansion mostly just changes how travel is perceived rather than who can access it. International flights still cost money, longer trips still need time taken off from work, and passports and visas still control who can travel freely. Steves does not take these barriers away, and he does not pretend to. His audience is mainly Americans who already have the legal and financial ability to travel. What changes is not the access itself, but what travel signifies.

That shift in meaning is crucial. Travel becomes less about exclusivity and more about character. Instead of showing you have money, it shows that you have curiosity, discipline, and perspective. Europe is framed as a place that can make Americans more thoughtful and self-aware, if they approach it the “right” way. This gives travel a kind of moral weight that separates Rick Steves from more commercial or entertainment driven tourism media. But it also turns travel into a way of performing moral awareness. The middle-class traveler is not just mobile, but ethically mobile or someone who becomes more open minded, wiser, and culturally aware through the trip.

That is why Rick Steves’ approach is not just about destinations; it is about shaping identity. His programs and books instruct viewers how to pack, where to stay, what to notice, and how to act, providing more than practical advice. It builds a model of the kind of person the traveler should become. Someone who is budget conscious but not cheap, informed but not arrogant, adventurous but not reckless, and appreciative without being naive. The consistency of that model across his media is a big reason he has become so influential.

What Steves actually does is morally reframe privilege. Travel is no longer about luxury or showing off but about personal growth. The American traveler is supposed to be curious instead of dominant, and self-aware instead of entitled. This matters because it changes how travel is practiced. The tourist is not the loud excessive stereotype, but more of someone trying to learn and gain a different cultural perspective.

At the same time, this idea of travel as self-improvement is not entirely new. Earlier forms of elite travel, such as the Grand Tour, were also framed around cultivation and personal development. In upper-class settings, cultivation was mostly

about refinement, social polish, and maintaining elite status. What Steves does is take that older idea and rework it for a middle-class audience. Now, growth is less about showing authority and more about being ethically aware, open minded, and humble. In that change, privilege is not something to show off, but something to handle more carefully. At the same time, there is a tension that is built into this. In *Travel as a Political Act*, Steves argues that travel can “broaden perspectives” and push back against ethnocentrism, using it as a tool for empathy and self-reflection. This idea shows up across his television shows, videos, and guidebooks, especially in how he stresses respectful behavior, understanding local history, and engaging with everyday life. Travel ends up being framed as something moral and educational, not just something you consume.

However, this ethical framework functions inside a system where freedom of mobility remains unequal. According to Dennison Nash (1981, p. 462), tourism depends on the ability to leave temporarily with the expectation of return. This assumption is tied closely to economic stability, legal status, and access to mobility. Americans who already have these types of mobility make up the majority of Steves’ audience. Instead of questioning these structural conditions, his work changes how travel is seen inside them.

His influence is defined by this tension. He redirects the tourist gaze through empathy, education, and cultural awareness, but through a carefully planned out experience. The tourist gaze is socially structured and varies by group and time, according to John Urry (Urry, 2002, pp. 1-2). By choosing what is displayed, outlining how it should be understood, and directing the traveler’s behavior, Steves’ media intentionally creates this gaze. Travelling becomes more self-aware and morally defined this way, but it does not become more materially accessible.

To completely understand this, looking closer at how this middle-class tourist identity is shown within Steves' media itself is vital. Not just a matter of what he says, but also how the media frames places, organizes interactions, and places the audience in connection with Europe and its citizens. The most obvious way that privilege changes is through these representational decisions. This distinction between cultural access and structural access is key to understanding Steves' influence.

Chapter 3 - The Construction of the Middle-Class Tourist

Rick Steves does more than just recommend places to visit. Through his media, he actively builds a model of what a “good” traveler should be. His shows, guidebooks, and lectures promote a specific set of behaviors and attitudes that define responsible travel. The type of traveler Steves encourages is curious, respectful, historically aware and willing to engage with the culture. These qualities are framed as helpful tips and as the right way to travel.

This process becomes clearer through Pierre Bourdieu's concept of cultural capital. For Bourdieu, cultural practices are tied closely to education and social origin, and they help to separate people by taste, knowledge, and competence (Bourdieu, 1984, pp. 1-2). More importantly, cultural capital is not only about what someone knows, but how comfortably they use that knowledge. Bourdieu shows that familiarity, confidence, manners, and the ability to act appropriately in cultural settings all become signs of distinction (Bourdieu, 1984, pp. 85-91). In the context of travel, this includes knowing how to recognize meaningful experiences, understanding historical context, and acting confident in unfamiliar places.

What matters here is that cultural capital in travel is not just about formal knowledge. It shows up in habits, tone, confidence, and judgment. It is in knowing how to read a menu, how to move through a train station, how to speak confidently, how to tell the difference between a tourist performance and everyday life, and even how to talk about your trip afterwards. On their own, these things seem small, but together they separate one traveler from another. They are what allow travel to function as a social marker, even when money is not being shown directly.

Rick Steves is important because of how his media turns these skills into something teachable. He makes cultural capital feel accessible. His books and

programs suggest that anyone can learn how to travel well. In that sense, he does open up certain kinds of knowledge. But at the same time, teaching those skills also reinforces their value as markers of distinction. So, he expands access to cultural competence, while also reinforcing it as a marker of distinction.

This does not make class disappear. It makes class more difficult to see. This is clearly evident in Steves' own writing. In *Travel as a Political Act*, he writes that "ideally, travel broadens our perspectives personally, culturally, and politically", giving travelers "more colors" to understand the world (Steves, 2017, p. 15). He also argues that "understanding people and their lives is what travel is about, no matter where you go" (Steves, 2017, p. 1). These statements show that Steves frames travel as moral and educational, not just recreational. But this also turns openness, awareness, and cultural understanding into markers of good travel.

The traveler who knows how to choose the "right" neighborhood, the "right" cafe, the "right" museum, and the "right" mode of transport is still using a form of distinction. The difference is that this distinction now comes across as moral rather than luxurious. It feels earned through awareness, not bought through wealth. That is part of Rick Steves' appeal, and it is also where his ideological power comes from. He makes privilege look humble. This comes through in his repeated emphasis on avoiding tourist traps and focusing more on "authentic" experiences, where he argues that "spending more money only builds a thicker wall between you and what you came to see" and that seeing the "real Europe" means traveling "through the back door" (Steves, 2019).

Rick Steves' media functions almost like a guide to understanding and acquiring this kind of cultural capital. But more importantly, it changes what counts as cultural capital in the first place. Rather than encouraging travelers to display wealth

through luxury hotels or luxury restaurants, Steves emphasizes knowledge and awareness. He explains the history behind cathedrals, museums, and neighborhoods, helping his viewers interpret what they are seeing instead of just simply observing it. A traveler who understands the historical significance of a small-town square or political context behind a monument comes off as more thoughtful and informed than someone merely taking photos of famous landmarks.

In this way, travel becomes less about consumption and more about interpretation. The tourist is encouraged to engage with places intellectually and culturally. Steves often reminds his viewers that understanding a destination is just as important as visiting it. By providing historical explanations, cultural background, and practical guidance, his media educates his audience on how to interpret the places that they visit.

This interpretation is not only internal but performed through visible behavior. Travelers are expected to show their understanding through behavior, such as choosing local restaurants over chains, using public transport, learning basic phrases, and approaching cultural sites with awareness. In this sense, cultural knowledge is visible in how one travels, and in how one returns and talks about those experiences. Cultural capital only gains value when it is displayed and recognized in a social context.

This knowledge becomes a marker of distinction. Travelers who understand what they are looking at show cultural competence, while the uninformed tourists come off as superficial. This interpretive dimension of tourism reflects what John Urry describes as the socially organized nature of the tourist gaze, where meaning is shaped by cultural expectations about what should be seen and experienced (Urry, 2002, pp. 1-3).

Another key concept that helps to understand Steves' approach to travel is Dean MacCannell's theory of staged authenticity, which helps explain this process. He argues that modern tourists often look for "authentic" cultural experiences, but what they encounter is often deliberately arranged or performed for them. Tourists crave access to the "back regions" of a place, more intimate and unfiltered glimpses of local life, but these are typically staged in ways that feel approachable and understandable for outsiders. The desire to move beyond obvious tourist attractions and discover the "real" culture of a place itself is part of the tourist experience (MacCannell, 1973, pp. 589-597).

Later work by Erik Cohen makes this more complex by showing that tourists do not all look for the same level of authenticity. Instead, many prefer experiences that balance unfamiliarity with structure, which allows them to engage with difference without becoming completely disoriented (Cohen, 1972, pp. 166-168). This helps to explain why Steves' version of "authentic" travel remains guided and curated. What feels like independent discovery is often carefully put together to feel meaningful while still being manageable for his audience.

Rick Steves' travel philosophy fits perfectly into this dynamic. His brand encourages travelers to move beyond the crowded tourist centers and instead explore the smaller neighborhoods, local markets and everyday local go-tos. A common theme in what he promotes is the idea of getting "through the back door" of Europe, suggesting that meaningful travel is when tourists step outside of the obvious tour routes. However, in practice these experiences are still carefully structured. His guidebooks lay out specific walking routes, recommend particular cafes and guesthouses, and even describe how travelers should interact with the

locals. The result is that what feels like a spontaneous discovery is actually more organized in ways that make it predictable and manageable for visitors.

Rather than removing the structure of tourism, Steves reorganized it. What looks like authentic cultural discovery is often a more curated experience designed to feel genuine while still being accessible to foreign travelers. This connects closely to MacCannell's argument that modern tourism produces controlled versions of authenticity. Travelers are encouraged to feel as if they are discovering hidden or more “real” cultural places, even when those experiences are shaped by the tourism industry itself.

Steves' work therefore does not simply expose travelers to authentic local life. Instead, it teaches viewers how to recognize and interpret authenticity. His media shows his audiences what kinds of places count as meaningful travel experiences and what kinds of tourist behavior should be avoided. Crowded tour buses, chain restaurants, and luxury resorts are shown as shallow tourism, while small family run businesses, neighborhood markets, and public transportation are presented as real cultural engagement.

Through these distinctions, Steves builds a clear hierarchy of travel styles. This hierarchy matters because it is a moral way of travel as much as aesthetic. The “good traveler” is not only more informed, but is also treated as more responsible, respectful, and serious. The “bad tourist”, by contrast, is framed as shallow, noisy, hurried, and overly commercial. That contrast gives travel behavior an ethical weight. It is not just about where you go anymore, but what kind of person you are while you're there. That framing is a big part of why Rick Steves' model is so powerful. It turns differences in taste into differences in character.

In Pierre Bourdieu's terms, this is how symbolic power works: preferences don't appear as just arbitrary choices, but it comes across as the natural or "right" way to see and act, even though they are socially produced (Bourdieu, 1984, pp. 66-68). In Steves' media, choosing local transport over packaged convenience, or local businesses over chain spaces, becomes more than practical. It signals seriousness and authenticity. The traveler who makes those choices seems more legitimate. That's how class forms of taste can be reproduced without openly announcing themselves as classed.

Travel becomes a way of showing cultural competence. The visible performance of competence matters a lot because travel is inherently public. What you do is always visible— where you eat, how you move, what you take pictures of, whether you slow down or rush, whether you ask questions or just take it in. Rick Steves consistently turns those choices into signals of value. A traveler who takes their time, learns a few phrases, understands some local history, and avoids overly commercial places is framed as travelling with a purpose. Someone who stays isolated or moves too quickly is framed as missing something important. Travel becomes a kind of stage where cultural distinction gets played out.

That also helps explain why his approach feels so affirming to a lot of viewers. It offers a way to stand out that doesn't depend on obvious wealth. You're told you do not need luxury to travel well, what matters is mindset, preparation, and willingness to engage. That's appealing because not everyone is seen as equally capable of being the "thoughtful traveler". The standards seem softer, yet they are still sorting people.

A traveler should show curiosity, cultural openness, and intellectual engagement with the world. These types of traits line up closely with the

middle-class values around education, self-improvement and cultural literacy. Travel is not just about leisure. It becomes more about personal development.

Rick Steves' media reinforces this identity framing travel as a form of learning. His work explains historical events, political contexts, and cultural tensions in ways that put the traveler more in the eyes of students. Museums are not just attractions but classrooms. Streets, markets, and neighborhoods become places where travelers can see and understand everyday life in another culture.

This educational framing strengthens the idea that travel should produce a more thoughtful and informed identity in a person. Rather than measuring a successful trip by luxury or entertainment, the traveler learns how deeply they have engaged with a place. The traveler returns home with more than just photos and souvenirs. The traveler returns with an expanded cultural understanding and new perspectives that can be shared. Even before social media, this was shown up in things like home slide shows, where travelers would present and talk through their trips to others. Rick Steves does something very similar in his public talks, where he walks his audience through his travels using photos and stories, turning the experience into something that is structured and meaningful.

In this sense, travel does not end when the trip is over. It continues through how the story gets told. You choose what to highlight, how you explain it, and the sense you made out of the experience afterwards. This is another way cultural capital works, it is not just about what you experienced abroad, but the meaning and knowledge that was gained from it.

The middle-class tourist identity promoted by Steves therefore relies on a balance between humility and expertise. The traveler is encouraged to be open-minded and respectful but is also knowledgeable and culturally literate. This

combination helps travelers to see themselves as different from both the wealthy and luxurious tourist and the uninformed mass tourist. In this way, Steves' travel philosophy helps to build a model of middle-class travel that values learning, authenticity, and cultural awareness.

This model also mirrors a specific moment in American middle-class culture. By the 1980s and 1990s, more Americans had the financial means to go abroad but still lacked the cultural confidence that earlier elite travelers had. At the same time, there was a growing emphasis on self-improvement, global awareness and ethical consumption. Steves' approach fits right into this change. He gives people a way to travel that feels thoughtful and informed, so middle class Americans can travel abroad without coming off as excessive or out of touch. The appeal is less about that travel just feels possible; it is about feeling like you're doing it the "right" way.

At the same time, this model of travel also shows broader middle-class ideals about education and self-improvement. Bourdieu shows that middle class culture values effort and learning and the process of gaining knowledge over time, rather than relying on status or what you're born into (Bourdieu, 1984, pp. 74-75). In this context, travel becomes a way of showing openness, curiosity, and intellectual engagement with the world. In this sense, the traveler is not just consuming destinations, but they are participating in a process of personal development. Visiting museums, learning local histories, and understanding cultural differences all become ways of acquiring a more informed worldview.

This framing helps to understand why Rick Steves' approach resonates so strongly with middle class audiences. The kind of travel he promotes does not take extreme wealth, but it does require cultural competence. That balance matters. For the middle class, identity is not something that is just given, it has to be built and

shown through choices and behavior. As Zygmunt Bauman argues, identity in modern life becomes an ongoing project which is shaped through individual effort and decisions (Bauman, 1996, pp. 18-19).

This also helps to explain why this kind of model is appealing in the first place. For many middle-class travelers, the issue is not only access, but the uncertainty that comes when knowing how to travel “correctly”, and present themselves in a different cultural setting. This is where Steves plays a significant part. Bauman notes that building your identity in modern times usually depends on guidance from those who claim they know how to do it properly (Bauman, 1996, p. 18). Steves’ model fits perfectly into that. He gives travelers a clear way to work on themselves through travel. Instead of just going somewhere, you are learning how to move, understand, and engage “correctly”. That is his whole appeal. It offers a way to feel more put together, aware, and legitimate without requiring elite status. Travel becomes something you build on through effort instead of something you inherit.

Travelers who follow Steves’ instructions, on the other hand, seem more genuine and responsible when they take public transportation, explore smaller neighborhoods, and engage with the locals. In this sense, being a “good traveler” becomes a distinctive trait in itself. Instead of showing status through visible wealth, travelers’ express status through cultural awareness and the capacity to navigate unfamiliar places correctly. This supports Bourdieu's argument that social differentiation is reproduced through cultural competence and taste, rather than just economic means (Bourdieu, 1984, pp. 66-68). Being able to travel “correctly” turns into a kind of symbolic capital that sets some travelers apart from others.

However, this travel model still relies on institutional privileges that are not distributed fairly, despite its emphasis on humility and cultural knowledge. The ability

to travel internationally takes financial resources, time away from work, and access to passports and visas that allow mobility across borders. While Steves' media teaches viewers how to travel ethically and thoughtfully, it still does not fundamentally change who is able to travel in the first place.

For this reason, the middle-class tourist identity that Steves promotes should be understood as a cultural transformation rather than a structural one. His media expands the cultural accessibility of travel by making Europe feel understandable and approachable for American audiences. However, the deeper inequalities that shape global mobility remain largely unchanged. Travel may become more ethical and self-aware, but it is not necessarily more accessible.

This tension between cultural openness and structural inequality is central to understanding Rick Steves' influence. Another reason this model works so well is that it lets middle class travelers see themselves as outside of tourism, even when they are still fully in it. Rick Steves constantly separates his ideal traveler from the typical "tourist". His audience is encouraged to see itself as more thoughtful, ethical, and more connected to local life than crowds around them. That distinction is powerful because it lets people feel different from mass tourism without actually stepping outside of it. You're still in the system, yet it feels more authentic and less compromised.

This is where authenticity and distinction really come together. Being a "temporary local" does not mean actually becoming local. It means performing a version of closeness to local life that is still temporary, curated, and easy to step out of. Steves' media makes that performance feel meaningful and morally satisfying. That is part of why it works, but also where it falls short. It offers a better way of doing tourism, but not a way out of the system itself.

Steves' work reshapes how Americans think about travel and encourages a more reflective and respectful approach to encountering other cultures. At the same time, the ability to travel in this form continues to depend on the same economic and political conditions that historically have shaped tourism.

Chapter 4 - The Limits of Democratization: Structural Barriers to Travel

Rick Steves presents travel as something open, approachable, and achievable for normal Americans. Through his television shows, guidebooks, and public talks, he reduces the cultural barriers that have historically made international travel feel more intimidating. He teaches his audience how to navigate foreign environments, interact with locals, and interpret unfamiliar places with more confidence. In doing this, he expands what access to travel feels like.

This expansion works at a level of perception rather than material access. Steves does not significantly change the circumstances that decide who is truly able to travel, even though he makes it seem more feasible. The ability to travel internationally continues to depend on resources such as money, time, citizenship, and legal mobility.

These factors matter because they show the gap between feeling like travel is possible and actually being able to do it. Rick Steves lowers a lot of the cultural barriers that make Europe seem confusing or intimidating. He explains what to expect, how to prepare, and how to avoid common mistakes. But none of that changes the basic reality that international travel still depends on money, passport access, and time away from everyday responsibilities. As József Böröcz shows, tourism is shaped by broader economic conditions, especially the availability of disposable income and free time made possible by industrial capitalism (Böröcz, 1992, pp. 712-714). In other words, he makes travel feel easier to imagine, but imagination is not the same as access. His media builds confidence more than it expands real mobility, because the ability to travel still depends on economic conditions outside of the traveler's control.

In this sense, economic barriers are the most apparent. Even the most budget-friendly version of European travel still requires financial stability.

Transportation, accommodation, food, and airfare are all expensive, especially for the working class, students, and those with little extra cash. While Steves promotes strategies for saving money and traveling cheaply, these are strategies that assume the traveler already has the basic necessities needed to leave their country. Because of this, his definition of accessibility reduces, but does not completely take away, the barrier of accessibility.

This uneven access is a reflection of broader structural patterns in global tourism. József Böröcz argues that tourism functions inside systems of “travel capitalism”, which grew out of industrial capitalism and reflects how unevenly that system develops across regions (Böröcz, 1992, pp. 708-710). In this system, mobility is not equally available. It depends on access to wealth, free time, infrastructure, and political stability, all of which are not distributed evenly at both national and global levels. Tourism is also a matter of access.

This structure is also built into how tourism actually functions. Dennison Nash argues that tourism comes out of the overlap between leisure and travel, but those conditions are not neutral. They are produced. In order for tourism to exist, people need both the resources and freedom from the “primary obligations” like work and everyday responsibilities (Nash, 1981, p. 461). That already limits who can travel.

Nash also shows that tourism is shaped by encounters between “tourist-generating” and “host” societies, where people from wealthier countries travel to less wealthy ones (Nash, 1981, pp. 461-463). These interactions are not equal exchanges. They are structured by wealth, mobility, and global position. So even when tourism looks like curiosity or a personal choice, it is still working inside those

inequalities. The ability to move freely across borders isn't universal; it's unevenly distributed, and tourism reflects that.

While Steves acknowledges these realities, the majority of his work is focused on how to travel effectively instead of on those who are excluded from travelling altogether. In *Europe Through the Back Door*, he emphasizes budget conscious strategies such as staying in simple accommodations, using public transport, and avoiding expensive tourist traps. His focus is on meaningful engagement, cultural awareness, and ethical behavior. Although this changes the values of tourism completely, the underlying structures of access are unchanged. Travel becomes more thoughtful and self-aware but not necessarily more equitable. This reinforces the main tension with Steves' work: he expands cultural access to travel while leaving the structural limits behind.

When looking past economic limitations alone, the gap between cultural accessibility and structural limitation becomes even clearer. Whoever is allowed to travel freely across borders is largely determined by political and legal circumstances. Passport strength, visa requirements and political relationships all determine how able one is to travel in ways that are largely invisible inside Steves' work.

While Steves' model first took shape in the 1980s and 1990s, structural inequality is still shown today. The Henley Passport Index shows how unequal global mobility remains: in the beginning of 2026, passports from countries like Singapore allow visa free or visa on arrival access to over 190 destinations, while passports from countries like Afghanistan allow access to less than 30. This gap shows that the issue Steves overlooks is more than historical. Mobility is shaped by nationality and global power. His audience is mostly American, people with some of the strongest

passports in the world, which makes travel to Europe much easier. That kind of access isn't universal. Many people do not have the same freedom to move.

This is one of the clearest places where Rick Steves' audience really matters. His work is aimed mostly at certain kinds of Americans, especially those who already have relatively strong legal mobility when it comes to traveling in Europe. That doesn't mean they're all wealthy, but it does mean many start from a position where international travel is at least institutionally possible, even if it is still expensive. His media often frames the remaining challenges such as preparation, mindset, and making good choices. For a lot of his audience, that's helpful. But it can also hide how travel is still out of reach for others, not because they lack motivation or knowledge, but because they lack structural freedom.

Time plays a huge role here as well. Being able to leave for a longer trip isn't about money, it's about work conditions. Tourism depends on being "free of primary obligations" which means having enough control over work, family, and everyday responsibilities to leave temporarily (Nash, 1981, p. 462). Some people have paid leave, flexible schedules, supportive employers, or jobs they can step away from more easily than others. That means travel is always tied to unequal control over your own time. Steves' advice assumes it's a traveler who can plan ahead, leave responsibilities behind, and spend enough time abroad to go beyond rushed, surface level experiences. This makes his version of travel feel more thoughtful and authentic, but it also reveals the class assumptions that are built into it.

This is the main contradiction at the center of Steves' influence. By making travel seem more understandable, ethical, moral and attainable, he broadens the definition of access while maintaining the fundamental limitations of access. From this, travel continues to be structurally exclusive while becoming more culturally

inclusive. The outcome of this is a type of democratization that is limited in terms of material access but is real in terms of perception and identity.

To fully understand how this tension works, it is not enough to only look at what Steves says about travel. It is just as important to look at how his media portrays travel visually and narratively. In addition to conveying his ideas, Steves' writing, guidebooks and programs demonstrate how sites are presented, how interactions are framed, and how the viewer is positioned in relation to Europe and its culture.

The difference between cultural and structural access is evident in the way travel is presented. Through the way his programs are narrated, edited and filmed, Rick Steves builds a version of travel that feels independent and authentic, yet still carefully guided and structured.

Chapter 5 provides a closer analysis of Rick Steves' media itself. By exploring recurring themes and the format in which his programs are produced, it becomes obvious that the middle-class tourist identity is intentionally constructed.

Chapter 5 - Media Representation and the Construction of Travel

Rick Steves' influence is not only found in what he says about travel, but in how his media presents it. Through his programs, guidebooks, and writing, he creates a consistent visual and narrative framework that shapes how his audience imagines and experiences Europe. Through recurring patterns in narration, scene selection, editing, and interaction, Steves does more than just guide travel. He builds a particular way of visualizing, interpreting, and moving through a foreign place. In this sense, his media actively produces the middle-class tourist identity.

One of the clearest ways this happens is through Steves' consistent positioning of his audience. His media rarely leaves viewers with just images. Instead, Rick Steves guides them through destinations with narration that explains what is significant, what is worth paying attention to, and how they should approach it. For example, in *Rick Steves Europe*, episodes show him walking through cathedrals, markets or city streets while pointing out specific details (like art styles, history, or everyday interactions) and explaining why they are important. The viewer isn't just observing, they are being guided on how to interpret the place.

This carries over into practical situations. In *Rick Steves Europe*, episodes also regularly include step by step demonstrations of things like using ticket machines, navigating train stations, or ordering in restaurants. He shows which buttons to press, how systems work, and what the expected behavior should be. From repeating this so much in his media, it turns unfamiliar situations into something manageable instead of being intimidating.

Over time, this turns uncertainty into competence. A train station feels easier once you know what to do. A restaurant feels more accessible once expectations are clear. A historical site becomes more meaningful when it has a narrative behind it.

This shift is the central part of his work, and it is how he builds the idea of the middle-class traveler, not someone naturally comfortable everywhere, but someone who learns to adapt to these kinds of places the “right” way.

At the same time, this representation is not neutral. The media Steves puts out consistently suggests that there is a right and wrong way to travel. Through his narration, editing, and comparison, his work leaves a clear delineation between the thoughtful traveler and the shallow tourist. The traveler he values is curious, respectful, historically aware and open to local culture, while the tourist he critiques is rushed, commercial, loud, and disconnected from everyday life. Crowded attractions, tourist traps and highly packaged experiences are often seen as less meaningful than neighborhood markets, local transit, and smaller cultural areas. These contrasts do more than offer travel advice. They create a type of moral hierarchy of travel behavior.

This hierarchy is often built through contrast editing and tone rather than direct criticism. Crowds, commercial signage, rushed movement, and highly packaged places get linked to a thinner kind of travel, one more focused on consumption than real engagement. Quiet streets, local businesses, everyday routines, and historically layered spaces get linked to depth, reflection, and authenticity. Even when Rick Steves does not explicitly say one is better, the way it is presented makes the judgment pretty clear. Viewers are not just shown what to prefer, but how to feel about those preferences.

This matters because representation becomes part of identity formation. When viewers see these contrasts over and over, they begin to value travel styles that signal patience, attention, and cultural awareness. In that sense, Steves’ media educates via the content he presents as well as via the manner in which the content

is framed and delivered. The media conveys information about Europe, as well as models on how to engage with it. That style of travelling becomes a key part of the middle-class tourist identity this thesis is tracking.

In Steves' narrative, this contrast is made clear. Throughout many of his episodes, he directly warns viewers to avoid "tourist traps" and instead to seek out the local experiences. For instance, when he guides his audience through major cities, he contrasts crowded and more commercialized areas with quieter neighborhoods, presenting the quieter places as more authentic and meaningful.

The representation of authenticity is closely tied to this moral code. Steves often draws attention to areas that seem ordinary, modest, local, and historic. Small cafes, family run hotels, and side streets are presented as indicators of deeper cultural understanding. Because they contrast with the commercial aspect and mass tourism, these locations feel more authentic. Yet, this authenticity is still carefully produced through media choices. What appears spontaneous or natural is usually chosen, narrated, and organized for the audience. In this regard, Steves helps construct authenticity by directing viewers toward places and experiences that feel "real", even though they are still carefully chosen, narrated, and structured for tourists (MacCannell, 1973, pp. 593-597).

In his guidebook *Europe Through the Back Door*, Steves consistently encourages travelers to "get away from the crowds" and experience the places more like a local. However, the routes, locations and interactions he recommends are still carefully chosen and structured. What appears as a spontaneous discovery is usually guided through specific instructions and curated suggestions. This mirrors MacCannell's idea that authenticity in tourism is not simply found but staged in ways that feel accessible and real to outsiders.

Steves also presents travel as a form of education rather than simple entertainment and consumption. His media rarely leave the pictures to do all the talking. Rather, political background, cultural interpretation, and historical explanation are combined with visuals. Churches, museums, neighborhoods and even meals are shown as opportunities to learn. The viewer is put in the shoes of a student in this academic approach, where they are not only expected to see but also comprehend Europe. Travel is linked to education, personal development and culture through his framing. These are not just practical values; they are vital qualities of the middle-class traveler persona that Steves' work contributes to.

Taken together, these representational choices show that Steves' media does more than just show destinations. It organizes how viewers should perceive Europe, which experiences are worthwhile, and what kind of traveler they should become. Travel is presented both as moral and educational, authenticity is visually built, and Europe is perceived to be more approachable. The middle-class tourist identity is actively being created and not just described by these recurring patterns.

The importance of this pattern is that it makes class-based values feel natural instead of socially constructed. Humility, curiosity, historical awareness, and engaging with local life start to seem like obvious "right" ways to travel, rather than preferences tied to a specific middle-class worldview. That is a critical reason why Rick Steves' media feels so convincing. These values aren't just stated, they are integrated into how travel destinations are produced and presented. Viewers are not only told what matters; they are shown a version of the world where those values already seem correct.

This does not invalidate those values. Many of them are genuinely thoughtful and useful. The point is that they also sort people. They separate the informed

traveler from the uninformed, the reflective traveler from the superficial one, and the more “serious” traveler from the consumptive tourist. In that sense, how Europe is represented becomes tied to how the self is imagined. Europe is framed as the place where the “right” kind of traveler can be constructed.

Conclusion

Rick Steves has played a significant role in reshaping how Americans imagine travel in Europe. Through his programs, guidebooks, and political travel writing, Steves presents travel as ethical, educational, and achievable for the ordinary person. Steves' media lowers the cultural barriers that make international travel feel intimidating by demonstrating how to navigate unfamiliar travel destinations and approach cultural differences with curiosity and respect. In that sense, Rick Steves has played a major role in rendering European culture more accessible to a broad American audience.

At the same time, this thesis has also argued that his version of accessibility is cultural rather than structural. While Steves portrays Europe to feel more understandable, manageable, and meaningful, he does not change the underlying conditions that determine who can travel in the first place. International mobility still depends on money, time, legal status, passport privilege, and freedom from everyday responsibilities. These barriers remain unevenly distributed. Travel might feel more accessible, but the actual logistics of travel are shaped by class and global inequality.

By looking at Rick Steves through the eyes of the tourist gaze, cultural capital, staged authenticity, and tourism inequality, this project has shown that his media does more than just describe travel. It actively builds the idea of a "good" traveler. That traveler should be historically aware, budget conscious, culturally curious, and committed to avoiding the tourism that is interpreted as shallow, rushed, or overly commercialized. In this way, Steves does not remove distinction from travel, he reorganizes it. Status is translated through taste, knowledge, behavior, and the ability to travel "correctly".

This is what makes Steves such a significant figure in the history of modern tourism media. His work reflects a broader shift where cultural competence matters just as much as, or even more than, visible wealth. Travel becomes a way of expressing middle class values like learning, humility, self-improvement, and moral awareness. Europe is not just a destination; it is an experience where those values are put into practice and come to life. In addition to photos, the traveler returns with an informed and thoughtful perspective of the world.

Ultimately, Rick Steves expands access and reproduces inequality at the same time. He opens up travel at the level of confidence by making Europe easier to understand and less socially intimidating. He does that, however, within a system where structural access is still unequal. This conflict is the source of his influence. He redefines travel as a morally meaningful activity for the middle-class rather than as luxury for the wealthy. The larger disparities that determine who is able to travel, cross borders, and engage in international tourism are still very much there. Because of this, Rick Steves should be seen not as someone who made travel fully democratic, but as someone who translated older forms of privilege into a new middle class language of ethics, learning, and cultural distinction.

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